

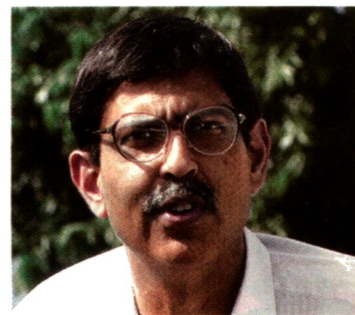
wore spectacles, 33 per cent children do so. "Imagine what this figure will be when they grow up," says Kennedy. About 22 per cent adults have dental problems compared to 30 per cent children—alarming since most polled children were long past the milk-teeth stage. When surveyed for family history of cardiac ailments, cancer, high blood pressure and diabetes, children outnumber adults (67:45 per cent). In other words, the risk for lifestyle diseases has risen by a whopping 22 per cent within one generation.

The numbers tell only part of the story. In a world that's raining food, making healthy choices about what and how to eat is not easy. The saga of little lives reflects that diet conundrum. Ankit Parashar of Lucknow might be just 12, but he has already been to the OT and back for what is essentially an adult affliction—gall stone. The doctor's diagnosis? Too much junk food. "Instead of preparing fresh tiffin, I used to give him money to buy food from the canteen," says his contrite mother, who works with a bank. "The shifting contours of the post-globalisation family—with more working mothers and both parents putting in more hours on the job—have created new circumstances of parenting," says Delhi-based counselor Gitanjali Kumar. As lives become busier, there is less time

to cook healthy meals, more people eat at restaurants, grab takeout food or buy frozen foods to heat up at home.

Ankit, obviously, belongs to the brigade of surveyed children, who score high on knowledge related to food (81 per cent), yet have appallingly disbalanced diets (29 per cent). "Except for the fact that more adults are overweight (61 per cent adults to 39 per cent children) in all other aspects of nutrition, children fare far worse than adults," points out Kennedy. Track the diet demon: 31 per cent drink less than two cups of milk every day; 37 per cent eat sweets with each meal daily; 43 per cent refuse fruits and veggies; pizzas and burgers form a major meal at least three times a week, for 32 per cent; 35 per cent frequent fast food centres more than twice a week.

When endocrinologist Dr Nikhil Tandon went around Delhi in 2006—measuring and weighing 21,485 schoolchildren between age 5-18—he was taken aback by the high burden of



“The soaring symptoms of metabolic dysfunction indicate early onset of chronic lifestyle-related disorders.”

DR NIKHIL TANDON
ENDOCRINOLOGIST, AIIMS

67% HAVE A GENETIC DISPOSITION TOWARD CHRONIC LIFESTYLE DISEASES, COMPARED TO 45% OF ADULTS.

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30% children have dental problems, compared to 22% adults

40% of children are seriously overweight